STEP 2

Problem Framing

From meeting commitments to honest closure

Prepared for the Fireflies.ai Product Management Launchpad capstone

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Purpose: define the most defensible problem to solve, map where commitment continuity can break down, and connect the opportunity to the case-study success target.

1. Executive summary

The problem should not yet be framed as “people forget their tasks” or “ownership is unclear.” The available research does not establish either as the single dominant cause. A more defensible framing is that the path from a commitment discussed in a meeting to a verifiable outcome can be fragmented across notes, task tools, spreadsheets, email, chat, and follow-up conversations. In the available interview evidence, several examples do not contain enough detail to confirm that a task began as a meeting commitment or to verify its final outcome.

This is a problem of continuity and verifiability to investigate—not a proven causal diagnosis. The next product direction should test whether making commitment ownership explicit, preserving the commitment’s context, and enabling lightweight honest closure can reduce loss between agreement and outcome without imposing work on people who have not accepted it.

Problem statement

For teams that make commitments in meetings, the transition from spoken agreement to an explicitly verified outcome can be difficult to follow across existing tools and handoffs. When the agreed action, willing owner, deadline or completion criteria, and final status are not consistently connected, participants may need manual follow-up and may lack a reliable view of whether the commitment was completed, reassigned, or deliberately dropped. Research so far suggests this continuity gap, but does not yet prove its prevalence or establish one root cause.

2. What the evidence supports—and what it does not

Evidence from research material	What it supports	What it does not prove
P13 described manually creating CRM tasks from meeting chat, with assignees and end dates. A report was delayed by SQL data quality; after data arrived, remaining work took about one day. The final closure was not established.	At least one workflow involved manual conversion of meeting discussion into a tracked task; dependencies affected progress.	That the task was overdue because of ownership ambiguity, or that it was never resolved.
P05 described a task expected the same day that remained unready about a week later; testing exposed a requirement mismatch and rework. The meeting origin and final outcome were unclear.	A tracked task can still be delayed by requirement mismatch and rework.	That this was definitively a meeting commitment or a representative pattern.
P02 described difficulty interpreting client language or slang and said some tasks may go unnoted. No verified 14-day outcome was available.	Capture and interpretation are plausible friction points worth further testing.	How often this occurs or its contribution to the 14-day resolution rate.
The 30 October 2026 interviewee described mainly offline management check-ins, Excel/Google Sheets, and no typical meeting-task assignment workflow.	Work practices differ; not every stakeholder or meeting context produces trackable commitments.	That the interviewee experienced a failed meeting commitment. This is useful negative/contextual evidence.
Across the available notes, many examples lack a complete trace from meeting agreement through ownership acceptance to a verified terminal state.	The research record has an evidence gap around end-to-end commitment continuity.	That fragmentation is already proven to be the most frequent or highest-impact root cause.

Interpretation: the evidence is directional and qualitative. It is appropriate for forming a testable problem hypothesis, but not for estimating prevalence or claiming that a particular feature will improve resolution.

3. Commitment lifecycle and likely loss points

The lifecycle below combines the case-study definition of resolution with the research questions and observed workflow examples. It is a working model for investigation, not a claim that every participant follows the same process.

Stage	Expected state	Potential loss point to validate
1. Commitment is discussed	A specific action or outcome is agreed during a meeting.	The discussion may be vague, conditional, or actually a general task rather than a commitment.
2. Commitment is captured	The action and relevant context are recorded or extracted.	The item may be omitted, misinterpreted, or separated from the meeting context.
3. Ownership is clarified	A person agrees to own the work; assignment is not assumed from mention alone.	A suggested owner may not have accepted responsibility, or a handoff may be unclear.
4. Deadline and success criteria are understood	The due date and what counts as complete are clear where relevant.	Different interpretations, missing dependencies, or changing requirements can create rework.
5. Work is followed through	The owner acts and communicates blockers or changes.	Status can be distributed across email, chat, spreadsheets, trackers, and meetings; follow-up may become manual.
6. Outcome is explicitly recorded	The item is marked done, reassigned with acceptance, or deliberately dropped.	Work may remain open, be silently abandoned, or be reported verbally without an auditable state.
7. Fourteen-day measurement	The commitment's terminal state is checked against its creation cohort.	Missing or ambiguous event records can make genuine closure difficult to measure.

Most important measurement distinction: "blocked," "late," "mentioned again," and "no longer visible" are not resolution states. For this capstone, resolution means explicitly marked done, reassigned after acceptance by the new owner, or deliberately dropped. Silent inaction does not count.

4. Primary barrier: a testable hypothesis

Primary barrier to test — weak continuity between agreement and verifiable outcome. A commitment may move between conversation, meeting notes, personal follow-up, and external work systems without one lightweight, trustworthy trail that preserves its context, accepted ownership, and explicit terminal state.

Why this framing is preferred: it can accommodate several evidence-supported possibilities—capture gaps, manual task creation, handoff friction, dependencies, and unrecorded outcomes—without prematurely claiming that one of them is the root cause. It also maps directly to the outcome the case study asks the product to improve: honest resolution within 14 days.

Confidence: moderate as a problem hypothesis; low as a confirmed causal explanation. The research has not yet quantified the frequency of each loss point, and several examples lack a verified end-to-end history.

5. Stakeholder tension

Stakeholder	What they need	Risk if the product gets it wrong
Person asked to do the work / individual contributor	Clear context, realistic expectations, ability to accept or decline ownership, and low-friction status updates.	A task is assigned without consent; reminders feel punitive; status becomes administrative overhead.
Person depending on the commitment / meeting organizer	A dependable answer on who owns the action, what is expected, and whether it reached closure.	They must repeatedly chase people or mistake silence for progress.

Manager or team lead	A team-level view of unresolved dependencies and outcomes, with enough context to unblock work.	The experience becomes individual surveillance or encourages performative completion.
Administrator / tool owner	A workflow that fits existing systems, permissions, and team practices without creating another backlog.	Duplicate records, difficult rollout, or more support and governance burden.
Buyer / budget owner	Evidence that the workflow improves execution and delivers measurable value worth paying for.	The product reports activity metrics without showing better commitment outcomes or business value.

The core tension is visibility versus autonomy. People who depend on a commitment need reliable closure information; the person expected to act needs control over whether they accept ownership and how they report a legitimate outcome. The product should support shared closure, not manager-only monitoring.

6. Business impact

The case study supplies a baseline of 28% of commitments resolved within 14 days and a six-month target of 45%. These are assignment inputs, not results from the interviews.

Measure	Value	Interpretation
Baseline 14-day resolution rate	28%	Case-study baseline
Target 14-day resolution rate	45%	Case-study target after six months
Absolute improvement required	+17 percentage points	45% minus 28%
Relative improvement required	About 60.7%	17 percentage points divided by 28%
Illustration per 1,000 eligible commitments	280 resolved at baseline vs. 450 at target	170 additional commitments resolved within 14 days if the target is achieved

This arithmetic illustrates the scale of the requested outcome; it is not a forecast of product impact. A business case must later test whether better commitment closure correlates with retention, paid conversion, expansion, or reduced coordination effort. Those effects cannot be claimed from the current qualitative sample.

7. What must be validated next

- Run targeted follow-up interviews that reconstruct one recent, specific meeting commitment from agreement through final outcome.
- Separate meeting commitments from general tasks, dependency requests, and work assigned outside meetings.
- Record whether the proposed owner explicitly accepted responsibility and how any reassignment was accepted.
- Collect evidence of the current record trail: meeting notes, task tracker, email/chat follow-up, deadline, blockers, and final status, where participants consent.
- Identify which lifecycle loss point recurs across independent participants and compare individual-contributor, manager, administrator, and buyer perspectives.
- Complete a hands-on audit of the current Fireflies action-item experience before making claims about existing UI capabilities.
- Verify whether the P15 record is independent from the similar P09/P10 scenario before reporting a final distinct-participant count.

8. Step 2 conclusion

The problem to carry forward is not simply that people forget tasks or that owners are unclear. It is that a meeting commitment may not remain connected to an accepted owner, clear expectations, follow-through, and a

verifiable outcome across the tools and handoffs people already use. The current evidence supports treating this as a focused hypothesis while leaving its prevalence and exact causal mechanism open to validation.

The next step is to generate and prioritize product options against this problem framing. The selected direction should reduce the effort required to establish ownership and record honest closure, preserve user autonomy, and avoid becoming a replacement project-management system.